‘There was a whole area we had nicknamed Kashmiri Bazar. Each Kashmiri here was part of a sleeper cell and they enjoyed the absolute support of the king’s men,’ Govind told me. ‘There were chances of influencing the king against these people, but he was blinded by the propaganda orchestrated by the Muslim leaders from Terai. The smaller a nation, the bigger its ego. It was not easy to carry out open operations when the plotters enjoyed state support. Some of our operations aimed to dismantle the militants’ plans before they were executed.’

As the R&AW moved closer to the Kashmiri militants in the Terai and Kathmandu, the Muslim leaders began floating non-governmental organisations as fronts to camouflage their terror activities. Into this high-pressure atmosphere, the R&AW deployed an undercover spy codenamed Sajid. Anantnag-born Sajid’s task was to infiltrate Kashmiri-linked organisations and engineer differences among the outfits supporting the militants. When Sajid began his espionage operation in the early 1990s, he developed close ties with two powerful Kashmiri militants. This enabled him to pass on vital intelligence inputs even as he worked on subverting these groups. He stole the bank account details of pro-Kash-miri organisations and manipulated them to create envy and anger among rival groups. Simultaneously, he sent messages to the security agencies about the arrivals and departures of militants to assist the agencies in their covert operations. Several terrorists were neutralised on the basis of warnings dispatched by Sajid. Flying solo, Sajid harvested actionable intelligence of high value for the R&AW. Working inside enemy territory, he had to have had nerves of steel.

In Govind’s words: ‘He was a confident trickster and a gifted operative, courageous and reliable. Sajid operated for more than